

Needs Analysis

Difficult Conversations

Portfolio Note: This needs analysis was developed to explain the rationale behind the Difficult Conversations eLearning module in my portfolio. The data and narrative below are fictional and are used to demonstrate the process, analysis, and instructional thinking that informed my design choices.

Analysis Information

Observed Problem

Management observed declining productivity and inconsistent work quality across several teams, with the most noticeable issues appearing on teams led by new and emerging leaders. These concerns were reflected in declining sales numbers, fewer repeat customers, missed follow-ups, and inconsistent communication with clients.

Through manager observations, performance reviews, and informal feedback from team members, leadership identified a common pattern: newer team leads were often uncomfortable giving direct feedback when performance concerns first appeared. Instead of addressing issues early, they tended to delay the conversation, soften the message, or provide feedback that was too vague to guide improvement.

As a result, small performance concerns often continued long enough to affect team output, client experience, and overall business results.

Survey Data

Current Performance

A simulated review of manager readiness and performance conversation habits showed several gaps.

Data Source	Simulated Finding
New manager survey respondents	24 managers
Managers who reported discomfort initiating difficult conversations	71%
Managers who reported waiting until an issue repeated three or more times before addressing it	62%
Managers who felt confident balancing empathy and accountability	38%
Sample feedback statements that lacked specific observable behaviors	48%

Sample conversation plans that included a clear follow-up date	35%
Employees who reported they were unsure of next steps after feedback conversations	46%

The data suggest that managers generally understand that feedback is part of their role, but many lack confidence and structure when the conversation involves interpersonal discomfort, ambiguity, or concern about harming the working relationship.

Management Interview Observations

After reviewing the survey data, follow-up conversations were conducted with managers and supervisors to determine whether the survey findings aligned with their observations of team lead behavior.

Managers confirmed that newer team leads were generally aware of performance issues but often struggled to address them early. Several managers described situations where a team lead noticed missed follow-ups or inconsistent communication but waited until the issue had affected a customer interaction or team deadline before initiating a conversation.

Managers also reported that when feedback conversations did occur, they often lacked specificity. Team leads tended to use general language such as “stay on top of things” or “communicate better,” rather than naming the specific behavior, impact, and expected change.

These conversations supported the survey findings and helped clarify that the performance gap was not simply a lack of knowledge. The more significant issue was the lack of a repeatable conversation structure and limited practice applying that structure in realistic situations.

Conclusions

The performance gap is not primarily caused by a lack of information. Most managers already know they are expected to give feedback and address performance concerns. The more significant gap is in applied communication skills, judgment, and confidence.

The analysis suggests four root causes:

Observed Issue	Likely Root Cause	Design Implication
Managers delay conversations	Discomfort with conflict and uncertainty about how to begin	Learners need low-risk practice opening the conversation.
Feedback is vague	Managers lack practice using specific, behavior-based language	Learners need to distinguish vague feedback from observable feedback.
Conversations become too soft or too harsh	Managers misunderstand the balance between empathy and accountability	Learners need to see the consequences of different communication choices.

Follow-up is unclear	Managers lack a repeatable structure for closing the conversation	Learners need practice creating next steps and follow-up expectations.
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Because the gap involves decision-making and communication behavior, a traditional information-only course would not be sufficient. Learners need to practice making choices in context and see how those choices affect the conversation.

Desired Behavioral Changes

The goal of this learning experience is to help new and emerging managers conduct early-stage performance conversations with clarity, empathy, and accountability.

After completing the learning experience, managers should be able to:

1. Open a difficult performance conversation directly and respectfully.
2. Describe the concern using specific, observable behaviors.
3. Explain the impact of the behavior on the team or work.
4. Invite the employee's perspective without losing focus on the concern.
5. Clarify expectations and agree on next steps.
6. Set a follow-up plan to support accountability and improvement.

The desired performance is not simply that managers “know” the steps of a difficult conversation. The desired performance is that managers can make effective communication decisions during a realistic conversation with an employee.

Recommendations

Training Recommendations

A scenario-based learning experience is recommended because the primary performance gap involves applied judgment, communication choices, and confidence in real workplace conversations. The survey data and management interviews suggest that new and emerging leaders do not simply need more information about the importance of feedback. They need structured practice in making effective choices during early-stage performance conversations.

The training should focus on helping learners:

1. Initiate performance conversations before small issues become larger problems.
2. Use specific, observable language when describing a performance concern.
3. Explain the impact of the concern on team performance, client experience, or business outcomes.
4. Balance empathy and accountability during the conversation.
5. Ask questions that invite the employee's perspective while maintaining focus on the performance issue.
6. Establish clear expectations, next steps, and a follow-up plan.

The recommended learning solution should include realistic workplace scenarios, decision points, feedback, and opportunities for reflection. Learners should be asked to choose how they would respond at key moments in a conversation and receive feedback on how those choices affect clarity, trust, accountability, and follow-up.

Because the skill requires practice and judgment, the training should move beyond a short informational overview. A more effective solution would include scenario-based practice, guided examples, a repeatable conversation framework, and a performance-support tool that learners can use when preparing for real conversations.

The training should remain focused on early-stage performance conversations involving communication, follow-through, and accountability concerns. It should not attempt to address formal discipline, termination, harassment investigations, legal documentation, or severe misconduct, which would require separate training and additional policy guidance.

Non-Training Recommendations

Training alone will not fully solve this performance issue. Managers also need workplace systems and expectations that support effective follow-through.

Recommended non-training supports include:

1. **Manager conversation planning tool**
Provide a simple preparation document that managers can use before a performance conversation. This should prompt managers to identify the specific behavior, impact, desired outcome, and follow-up plan.
2. **Shared performance conversation expectations**
Clarify organizational expectations for when managers should address early-stage performance concerns. This helps reduce the tendency to wait until problems become more serious.
3. **Manager coaching or peer practice**
Encourage new managers to rehearse difficult conversations with a supervisor, mentor, or peer before holding the real conversation.
4. **Follow-up documentation process**
Create a lightweight process for documenting agreed-upon next steps and follow-up dates, especially for repeated performance concerns.
5. **Leadership reinforcement**
Senior leaders and supervisors should reinforce that early, respectful feedback is part of effective management, not a sign of conflict or failure.

These recommendations address environmental and process factors that training can support but not fully replace.